Example Behavior Change Poster: Increasing Feline Exposure to Improve Hearth Health

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Feline Exposure

Research suggests that companion animals may improve both physical and psychological health.

- Feline interaction has been associated with improved cardiovascular health, including lower resting heart rate and improved blood pressure regulation (Diesel & Gaston, 2025).
- Shared pet interaction may reduce stress and improve relationship satisfaction (Nixon, 2026).
- Companion animals may provide emotional grounding and resilience during stressful periods (Scheuler et al., 2025).

Project Rationale

In addition to the TOTALLY REAL RESEARCH that certainly is NOT named after my cats, I found this behavior important to change because my cats regularly scream-meow at me for attention. I believe that spending more time with my cats may help reduce the amount of meowing in our household. Furthermore, as a tenure-track professor, I often find myself stressed. Increasing my feline exposure to reduce stress could improve my heart health and overall quality-of-life.

Thus, I created a SMART goal, designed a research approach, and tracked my ability to make this behavior change.



SMART Goal

My goal was to increase intentional time spent spoiling my cats to at least 30 minutes per day for five days. I ensured my goal followed SMART guidelines in the following ways:

- **Specific**: I defined intentional spoiling activities such as brushing, play sessions, cuddle time, and treat-based enrichment.
- **Measurable**: I tracked the total number of minutes spent engaging in each of these activities every day.
- **Achievable**: By reducing the time doom-scrolling on TikTok, I could realistically spend at least 30 minutes every day spoiling my cats.
- **Relevant**: Research indicates that feline interaction may improve stress regulation and heart health, which are both concerns for tenure-track college professors.
- **Timebound**: I tracked the behavior change over five days.

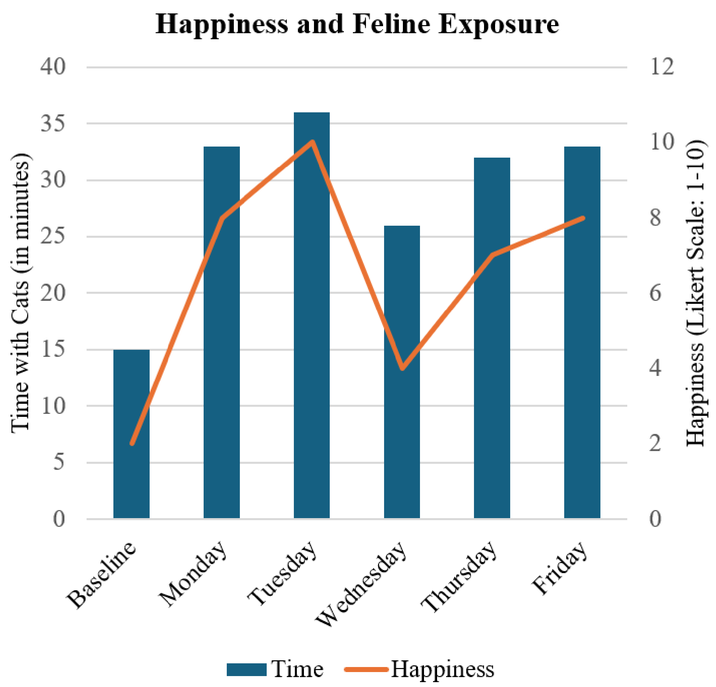
Data Collection Plan

To measure my behavior, I created an Excel spreadsheet in which I recorded the number of minutes spent intentionally spoiling my cats each evening, with categories for each type of activity. Spoiling activities were operationally defined as brushing, interactive play with toys, lap time without electronic distractions, and treat-based enrichment activities. Only intentional, distraction-free time was counted. Minutes were recorded in total minutes per day, per category. Additionally, I recorded a happiness rating on a scale of 1 (extremely unhappy) to 10 (extremely happy), to determine if I felt better in connection with the time I spent with my cats.

Results

Key Findings

- Average interaction increased from 14 minutes/day to 32 minutes/day
- Goal achieved on 4 of 5 days
- Highest engagement: 36 minutes
- Lowest engagement: 26 minutes on a busy workday
- Collection errors: Did not capture specific activity times
- Pattern in experience: I was less likely to spend time with my cats on days I was busy. This created a compounding effect on stress and happiness, where I was more stressed because I had more work, while not being able to reduce stress by spoiling my cats.



Greater intentional interaction with cats was associated with higher happiness ratings throughout the intervention.

AI Feedback

To improve my behavior change project in the future, I provided ChatGPT (2025) with an explanation of my SMART goal, plan, and success.

Main Feedback:

- Pair cat time with an existing habit (e.g., after dinner)
- Track stress levels in addition to happiness
- Implement a weekly reward system
- Use environmental reminders

Items for Future Implementation:

- Habit pairing
- Daily stress tracking

Reflection & Conclusion

What Worked?

- Behavior was enjoyable
- Goal was clearly defined
- Tracking increased accountability

Challenges

- Busy workdays reduced available time
- Intervention was brief
- I kept switching between activities, so I was unable to get the amount of time with each specific activity

Future Directions

- Track behavior for a longer period
- Consider two 15-minute sessions per day
- Include daily stress ratings
- Utilize an established happiness scale

I implemented a brief behavior change to increased intentional interaction with my companion animals to decrease stress and improve heart health. My results suggest that spending dedicated time with pets may be an accessible strategy for improving well-being and managing stress. Personally, the intervention reinforced the value of making time for meaningful interaction with my cats.

References

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